Sherif Abaza

General Manager | Marketplace Supply, Community and Operations

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SUMMARY

Operator and founder with 20+ years in high-ownership roles. For eight years I was on the executive team of **Withlocals**, a venture-backed travel experiences marketplace, first as Chief Growth Officer and then as Chief Community Officer. I owned the supply side end to end: recruitment strategy, onboarding, activation, rewards and retention for **2,000+ hosts across 80+ countries**, a destination management team of 16, and acquisition through paid, referral and direct outreach channels. I scaled the marketplace from 50 to **300+ cities** using data-driven market prioritisation and tracked performance in Looker Studio.

Before that I founded and ran **Sphere Events** for ten years, growing it to **140 people and USD 8M+** in annual revenue with full P&L ownership, and co-founded the MENA business of a mobile loyalty startup (**USD 1.8M** raised, 35-person team across 6+ markets). I work in five languages and have recruited and led multinational teams across the Middle East and Europe.

CORE SKILLS

- Marketplace supply growth and community
- Paid acquisition, referral and outreach programmes
- Supplier onboarding, activation, rewards and retention
- Multi-market expansion and market prioritisation
- Budgets, P&L and capacity planning
- Building and leading operations teams
- Metrics and dashboards (Looker Studio)
- Working with Product and Engineering
- Executive communication and stakeholder management
- Multilingual, multinational workforces
- Founder-level ownership in ambiguity

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Withlocals B.V. · Eindhoven, Netherlands

Chief Community Officer | Jul 2022 – Jul 2026

- Owned the full host supply funnel for a technology-driven travel and experiences marketplace across **80+ countries**: recruitment strategy, a scalable recruitment and onboarding process, activation, host rewards programmes and retention.
- Led the destination management team of **16 people**, responsible for a network of **2,000+ hosts** and consistent quality across markets.
- Recruited hosts through **paid acquisition, referral programmes and direct outreach**, balancing channels by market.
- Tracked supply, activation and retention performance in Looker Studio dashboards built with Product and Engineering.

Chief Growth Officer | Nov 2018 – Jul 2022

- Scaled the marketplace from 50 to **300+ cities**, building data-driven frameworks for market prioritisation and operational efficiency.
- Led the pivot to virtual and hybrid experiences during the pandemic, launching a proprietary platform that served **70+ global corporate clients** within 90 days, with no paid acquisition.
- Partnered with Product and Engineering on the internal tools and dashboards behind host performance, retention and operational clarity.

Abaza Business Services · Valkenswaard, Netherlands / Global

Founder & Managing Director | Jan 2019 – Present

- Strategic and operational partner to **Barry Callebaut** across its global event portfolio: strategy, budget ownership and financial oversight, executive stakeholder alignment, and vendor and agency selection.
- Led end-to-end delivery of client programmes at **COP27, COP28 and COP29**, leading multinational teams, master timelines and on-site operations.
- Operations lead for global agencies **Jack Morton, Shelton Fleming and Impact XM**, managing in-market vendor and supplier teams.
- Designed and shipped two software products through AI coding agents, and use AI daily for analysis, planning and operations.

FrontFlip (me360) · Kansas City, USA / MENA

CEO, Middle East & North Africa | Mar 2010 – May 2015

- Co-founded and led the regional business of a mobile loyalty and engagement startup, raising **USD 1.8M** in early-stage funding and building a 35-person cross-functional team across 6+ markets.
- Led market localisation, UX design and rollout of one of the region's earliest app-based customer engagement platforms.

Sphere Events and Communication · Dubai, UAE
Founder & Managing Director | Aug 2008 – Oct 2018

- Founded and led the company for ten years, growing it from a sole operator to **140 people and USD 8M+** in annual revenue, with full P&L accountability for **150+ projects a year**.
- Built and managed a large freelance and supplier network (production crews, technicians, venues, talent) that scaled up and down with demand.
- Built the operational playbooks, supplier frameworks and QA processes that kept quality consistent across formats and markets.
- Clients included **Siemens, Ericsson, Porsche, Cartier and Emaar**.

Earlier career · Dubai, UAE
Business Development & Operations Manager, Sundance Events | Jan 2006 – Aug 2008
Senior Account Manager, ASDAA Burson-Marsteller | Sep 2004 – Dec 2005

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Computer Engineering
Arab Academy for Science, Technology and Maritime Transport, Alexandria, Egypt

LANGUAGES

Arabic (native), English (native), French (excellent), Spanish (excellent), Dutch (working), Polish (working)

WORK AUTHORISATION

Dutch (EU) citizen; requires US visa sponsorship